

To be a business owner also requires that you have the desire to be self-employed. If you hate the thought of being outside the corporate environment, entrepreneurship may not be your calling. The most successful business owners we have interviewed have one characteristic in common: They all enjoy what they do. They all take pride in “going it alone.”

Consider what a multimillionaire once told us about being self-employed:

*There are more people [employees] today working at jobs that they don't like. I'll tell you honestly that the successful man is a guy who works at a job, who likes his work, who can't wait to get up in the morning to get down to the office, and that's my criteria. And I've always been that way. I can't wait to get up and get down to the office and get my job under way.*

For this fellow (a widower without children), it's not the money. In fact, his estate plan calls for all his wealth to go to the undergraduate scholarship fund at his alma mater.

How did this fellow and others like him select the businesses they wanted to start? He was well trained in college by engineering and science professors, many of whom were also entrepreneurs. These professors were his role models. Most successful business owners had some knowledge or experience with their chosen industry before they ever opened their own businesses. Larry, for example, worked for more than a dozen years selling printing services. He was the top performer for his employer. But after growing tired of the constant fear that his employer would go bankrupt, he considered opening his own printing company. He sought our advice in this regard.

We asked Larry a simple question: “What's the number-one thing that printing companies need?” He immediately responded, “More business, more revenue, more customers.” Thus, Larry answered his own question. He did start his own business, but not his own printing company. He became a self-employed broker of printing services. He now represents several outstanding printing firms and receives a commission on every sale he makes. His business has little overhead.

Before starting his own business, Larry told us he did not have the courage to be an entrepreneur. He told us that every time he even thought